

The Flavors of Europe

From the Silk Road gateway of Tbilisi, Georgia, and the rolling plains of Portugal's Alentejo to the volcanic islands of Sicily and the chill highlands of Scotland, the European continent is a complex patchwork of landscapes, cultures, and cuisines. The tale of its tables is a celebration of local products augmented by the spoils of empire, the fruits of trade, and the enthusiastic embrace of meats, vegetables, and cooking techniques from North Africa, Asia Minor, and the Americas.

Certain flavors pale when uprooted. The rich-tasting Greek fava bean becomes a plain-Jane legume in other soils. Shavings of Italian black truffles lend an earthy musk to pastas and risottos wherever they're used, but never with such piquancy as in the dishes of Umbria. The exquisite Roman artichoke anywhere else is just another globe thistle, while the distinctive basil and olive oil of Genoa combine to make Ligurian pesto the green queen of pasta cuisines.

Warm water or cold, sweet or salt – the oceans, lakes, and rivers of Europe are the starting point for many iconic dishes, from

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steamed mussels in Brussels to fried fish on Whitby's North Sea strand.

The crystalline Adriatic waters of Croatia teem with succulent scampi – all the better cooked with tomato, garlic, and white wine. In the Caspian

Sea, armor-plated sturgeon produce delicious, rich caviar, while the pink-fleshed salmon from the mouths of icy Norwegian rivers are salt-cured to create the pungent delicacy called gravadlax.

Across Europe, cooks make fish stews that are virtual census counts of their harbors. Marseille bubbles with bouillabaisse spiked with a garlicky *rouille*, while Barcelona sings the light opera of fish known as *zarzuela*. Far to the north, the white fish of Belgian

rivers form the toothy basis of Ghent's creamy *waterzooi*. All three fish stews rely on the ethereal but haunting overtones of saffron, the crocus spice brought to Europe in the North African conquest of Iberia. The Moors left an even more indelible stamp on European cuisine by introducing the short-grained rices essential to Valencia's seafood-studded paellas and Italy's unctuous, saffron-scented *risotto milanese*. Masters of metallurgy, the Moors also introduced the clamshell-shaped steaming vessel that became the Portuguese *cataplana*, though it took the Portuguese Christians to concoct the nation's signature dish of pork and clams.

New World Ingredients

Iberian seafarers revolutionized European cuisine with their New World culinary finds. Potatoes swiftly took hold in central Europe, forming the basis of the Swiss rösti, the *Reiberknödel* dumpling of

Right The vineyards of Burgundy, France, play an important role in the area's cuisine
Below Alfresco dining in Istanbul, Turkey, opposite the 17th-century Blue Mosque

